

Left (top to bottom) Four types of *gao*, or steamed dumplings; the main gateway into Sydney's Chinatown; dim sum dishes with, in the foreground, "phoenix talons" (chickens' feet)

Below (top to bottom) Paper lanterns strung across Gerrard Street, in the heart of London's Chinatown; rolled and skewered steamed pork with chili pepper and green onions



LONDON, UK

London's dim sum scene has exploded since the upmarket and innovative Hakkasan opened in the late 1990s, making Chinese food hip, upping the bar for dim sum cooking everywhere, and making London arguably the best city for Chinese food outside Asia.

Phoenix Palace moderate

5 Glentworth Street, NW1; www.phoenixpalace.co.uk

You know where you are with Phoenix Palace's enjoyably familiar dim sum selection – barbecued pork buns, sesame shrimp rolls, and crunchy fried yam dumplings – all cooked to perfection and served in a polite, bright setting.

Yi-Ban moderate

London Regatta Centre, Dockside Road, Royal Albert Dock, E16; www.yi-ban.com

A converted warehouse serving first-class dim sum with a stylish Docklands view. Their shrimp and chive dumplings, pork and preserved egg congee, and marinated pork with jellyfish are good enough to make you overlook the occasionally offhand service.

Hakkasan expensive

8 Hanway Place, W1; www.hakkasan.com

Hakkasan's success has brought it a Michelin star. The stylish wooden decor invokes a romanticized image of China, which suits the food – venison puffs and flying fish roe have never appeared on menus in dim sum's homeland. Don't miss the magnificent seafood dumpling consommé.

SAN FRANCISCO, CA

San Francisco's Chinatown is one of the largest outside Asia and the oldest in America. Beneath ornate 19th-century buildings, including a dragon-embossed Bank of America, lie dim sum restaurants that are fairly conservative, but with high-quality food.

Yong Kee inexpensive

732 Jackson Street; (415) 986 3759

A carry-out bakery that's a favorite with local Chinese, with many dim sum offerings – though it's pretty well mandatory to try their big chicken buns and handmade *char siu* rolls. There's no English sign outside, but it's not hard to find.

Ton Kiang moderate

5821 Geary Boulevard (between 22nd and 23rd Ave.); www.tonkiang.net

Though most of the excellent dim sum menu here is mainstream Cantonese, Ton Kiang is unusual in also serving Hakka dishes from northeastern Guangdong province, on the border with Fujian (Hokkien). Shrimp-stuffed eggplant is a Hakka classic.

Yank Sing moderate

One Rincon Center, 101 Spear Street; www.yanksing.com

This family-run institution has been feeding the community since 1958, building up an enviable reputation for fresh tastes and skillful presentation. Must-tries are the *xiaolong bao*, chicken *fan gwor* dumplings, and steamed rice packets.

On the Menu

Char siu bao A steamed bun, light and fluffy around its savory stuffing of barbecued pork.

Cheung fun Thin, light rice noodle sheets folded around shrimp or roast meat fillings and flavored with a soy-oil dressing.

Chun goon "Spring roll," the best-known dim sum outside China, though not so popular at home. Usually stuffed with pork shreds and bean sprouts, and served with a sweet-and-sour sauce.

Dan ta Flaky pastry cup filled with egg custard. Macau's Portuguese-influenced version is grilled on top.

Fan gwor Clear-skinned dumplings from Chaozhou (Teochew) in China's eastern Guangdong province. Usually filled with seafood and light-flavored vegetables.

Foong jow Literally "phoenix talons," actually chickens' feet, prepared in various ways. The skin has a classic, gelatinous crunchiness, but they're fiddly things to eat, with dozens of tiny bones.

Har gau Steamed, clear-skinned shrimp dumplings; the shrimp should be slightly crisp and the wrapping light. A yardstick for a fine dim sum kitchen.

Jook Bland rice porridge, perked up with savory ingredients; an ideal complement to richer dim sum dishes. Sometimes known by its Indian name, "congee."

Law bak go Fried turnip-paste patty flavored with dried shrimp and *lap cheung* sausage.

Mong gwor pu deen A refreshing, un-Chinese dessert of Southeast Asian origins, comprising puréed mango pulp set with gelatin.

Nor mai gai Chicken pieces steamed inside a glutinous rice packet, wrapped in a scented lotus leaf. They tend to be rather heavy and filling.

San jook ngau yuk Steamed, springy-textured beef balls, served with a distinctive, aromatic soy sauce.

Siu mai Ubiquitous, open-topped steamed pork-and-shrimp dumplings.

Inevitably ordered because of their good looks, they can be delightfully firm and juicy, but are often rather heavy.

Woo gok Crisp and curiously "hairy" fried taro croquettes, filled with minced beef. Surprisingly filling.

Xiaolong bao Addictively tasty steamed pork and shredded cabbage dumplings from Shanghai. They fill with broth during cooking, making eating tricky – bite a hole in the side to drain them first.